AI & NO-CODE TOOLS LAB · LESSON 3 OF 3

Tools and Learning Resources Directory: How to Choose and Evaluate Tools

Use a structured directory of tools across sixteen categories, from spreadsheets and SQL to MCP and portfolio tools, and evaluate any AI or no-code tool with a repeatable sheet covering purpose, features, limits, strengths, weaknesses and alternatives.

Gap-fill lesson · ✦ 2026 · Beginner · ⏱ 75 min

By the end of this lesson you can

- Find a tool in the directory by category and learning order
- Evaluate an AI or no-code tool with the evaluation sheet
- Check prices and features on the official page and record the date
- Choose between alternatives with stated criteria

Why a directory and a sheet

The tool landscape changes every few months. New products appear, prices change and features move between free and paid plans. Two things keep a learner or a team from being overwhelmed: a **directory** that groups tools by the job they do, and an **evaluation sheet** that gives every tool the same questions. This lesson shows how to use both.

CASE STUDY **Which tool should we use?**

A small team needs to automate a weekly report and is choosing between a no-code workflow tool, a spreadsheet macro and a small Python script. Without a common sheet, the choice depends on who demonstrates best. With one, the team can compare the same facts and decide.

The sixteen categories

#	Category	Typical tools (examples)	Course link
1	Excel and spreadsheets	Microsoft Excel, Google Sheets	Excel track
2	SQL and databases	PostgreSQL, DuckDB, SQL Server	SQL track
3	Power BI and BI platforms	Power BI Desktop, Tableau	Power BI and Tableau tracks
4	Python and coding environments	Python, Jupyter, VS Code	Python track
5	Statistics and mathematics	Python statistics libraries, textbooks	ML track
6	Machine learning	scikit-learn	ML track
7	Data engineering	dbt, Airflow, Spark	Data engineering track
8	Cloud platforms	AWS, Azure, Google Cloud	Data engineering track
9	Generative AI	Model provider APIs and documentation	GenAI track
10	RAG and vector databases	Embedding services, vector stores	GenAI track
11	AI agents	Agent frameworks	Agents track
12	MCP and API development	MCP servers, OpenAPI tools	Agents track
13	No-code automation	n8n, Make, Zapier	Tools track
14	Git and development	Git, GitHub	Python track
15	Product and project management	Issue trackers, document tools	Governance track
16	Portfolio and interview preparation	Portfolio sites, practice platforms	Career track

Each entry in a full directory should record: purpose, a beginner explanation, the official site, the official documentation, the official tutorial, whether it is free or paid, the course module it supports, a learning order and one exercise.

::::warn Check the official page, and note the date Prices, limits and features change. Before you rely on any of them, open the official page, note the date you checked, and record the plan name exactly as the vendor shows it. Third-party summaries and comparison sites often disagree with each other. ::::

The tool evaluation sheet

Use the same twelve questions for every tool you consider:

Question	What to write
What does it do?	One sentence in plain language
Why use it?	The problem it solves for your task
Who should use it?	The role, skill level and team size it suits
Main features	Three to five features that matter for your task
Free, freemium or paid?	Exact plan names and what each includes, with the check date
Limits	Usage caps, data limits, rate limits, seats
Strengths	Two or three, with evidence from a test
Weaknesses	Two or three, with evidence from a test
Alternatives	Two other tools in the same category
Practical example	One real task you ran in it
Official documentation	The link you used
Exercise	One thing you can do in 30 minutes to try it

Using the sheet: a worked comparison

The team above compares three ways to automate the weekly report.

Question	No-code workflow	Spreadsheet macro	Python script
Purpose	Connects apps on a schedule	Repeats steps in one workbook	Reads data, builds the report, logs runs
Who	Non-coders with several apps	Analysts who know the workbook	Analysts who can code
Main limit	Usage caps on the free plan	Only works in that file	Needs setup on the machine that runs it
Weakness	Hard to test complex logic	Fragile when data moves	Someone must maintain the code
Test in 30 minutes	Build the trigger and one step	Record a macro on sample data	Run the script on last week's file

Decision rule: choose the least powerful tool that meets the requirement with the lowest maintenance cost. For a single workbook, a macro is enough. For many apps on a schedule, a workflow tool. For logic that must be tested and versioned, a script.

How to learn a new tool in order

1. Read the purpose and the beginner explanation.
2. Complete the official tutorial with sample data.
3. Build one small task from your own work.
4. Write the evaluation sheet from what you saw, not from marketing pages.
5. Decide: keep, watch, or drop, with the reason.

INTERVIEW CORNER

How do you decide between two AI tools for a team?

Start with the task and the data. Score both tools on the same evaluation sheet, run each on the same three test cases, and compare cost per completed task, the errors found and how much human checking each needs. Decide on the measured result, record the date, and plan to re-check in six months.

::::key What to remember - A directory groups tools by the job they do, across sixteen categories. - Use one evaluation sheet for every tool so that comparisons are fair. - Check prices and features on official pages and record the date. - Choose the least powerful tool that meets the requirement with the lowest upkeep. ::::

Quick quiz

5 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. Why use the same evaluation sheet for every tool?

A It is required by law

B It makes comparisons fair and based on the same facts

C It replaces testing

D It removes the need for alternatives

Answer: B. Consistent questions reduce bias from demonstrations.

2. Where should a tool's price be checked?

A On a comparison blog

B On the official page, with the check date recorded

C In a friend's message

D In the tool's marketing video

Answer: B. Official pages are the reference; third-party summaries can be out of date.

3. The decision rule in the lesson recommends:

A The most powerful tool available

B The least powerful tool that meets the requirement at the lowest upkeep

C The newest tool

D The most expensive tool

Answer: B. Simplicity and maintenance cost are part of the decision.

4. Which category would a tool for building an API description belong to?

A Excel and spreadsheets

B MCP and API development

C Statistics

D Portfolio

Answer: B. OpenAPI and related tools fall under API development.

5. What should a learner do after the official tutorial?

A Stop and move on

B Build one small task from their own work and write the evaluation sheet

C Buy the paid plan at once

D Share the tool on social media

Answer: B. Hands-on use with your own task produces the real evidence.

EXERCISE **Evaluate one tool**

Choose one AI or no-code tool you use or are considering. Complete the twelve-question evaluation sheet using its official page, one 30-minute test on your own task, and a comparison with two alternatives. End with a keep, watch or drop decision and the date you checked the official pricing.

Show solution (worked answer)

Hints: keep the test small and identical for each tool. Put the check date in the free-or-paid cell. If the official page does not state a limit, write "not stated" rather than guessing.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.